

DSP-1.0

Dharma Standard Protocol

Founding Specification — Private Draft

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Status: Internal Working Specification

Compatibility Before Replacement.

Purpose

DSP-1.0 is the protocol specification that sits between the Dharma Constitution and future implementations. The Constitution defines values, DSP defines behavior, and later documents define implementation details.

The protocol is designed to interoperate with existing ecosystems rather than replacing them.

Protocol Principle 1 — Compatibility Before Replacement

Every existing protocol should be able to speak Dharma without abandoning its own language. Dharma should become the shared authority layer that connects heterogeneous systems.

The Six Protocol Rules

Rule	Meaning
DSP-1	Every consequential action requires an Authority Chain.
DSP-2	Every delegation preserves lineage.
DSP-3	Authority cannot expand during delegation.
DSP-4	Constraints travel with authority.
DSP-5	Every effect produces evidence.
DSP-6	Revocation propagates through descendants.

Authority Packet (DAP)

Every Dharma implementation exchanges authority through a conceptual Authority Packet. The wire format is intentionally not frozen in DSP-1.0.

Version — Protocol version.

Authority-ID — Unique authority reference.

Issuer — Authority creator.

Subject — Authority recipient.

Purpose — Reason for delegation.

Constraints — Operational limits.

Delegation Rule — Propagation policy.

Lifetime — Validity period.

Evidence — Verification anchor.

Authority Handshake

A shared handshake establishes a common transaction model across different ecosystems.

- Authority Grant — Origin creates authority.
- Authority Accept — Recipient accepts authority.
- Authority Confirm — Authority becomes active.
- Action — Work executes within authority.
- Evidence — Verifiable record is produced.

Authority State Machine

Authority behaves as a state-transition system rather than a static permission.

Transition	Meaning
Create	Authority is born.
Delegate	Authority moves downward.
Attenuate	Authority becomes more restrictive.
Merge	Compatible authority combines.
Split	Authority divides into bounded descendants.
Revoke	Authority becomes invalid.
Expire	Authority ends naturally.

Working invariant: Child authority should never exceed parent authority.

Cross-Protocol Compatibility

DSP is intentionally designed to coexist with existing ecosystems.

Ecosystem	Dharma Role
MCP	Authority layer for tool calls.
A2A	Authority continuity between agents.
HTTP APIs	Authority metadata alongside requests.
Payment Systems	Delegated spending authority.
Enterprise Software	Organizational authority mapping.
Robotics	Physical action authority.

Adoption Strategy

Rather than asking companies to replace OAuth, MCP, A2A, or payment protocols, DSP proposes an additive layer that allows those systems to exchange authority while preserving their own identities.

The protocol is intended to become useful before it becomes ubiquitous.

Version Commitment

DSP-1.0 is a constitutional specification rather than a finalized wire protocol. Future versions may formalize serialization, cryptographic proofs, and reference implementations while remaining compatible with Principle 0 and the Dharma Constitution.